Food-Security in Yemen: A Rising Concern due to Conflict

Executive Summary

High levels of food insecurity, famine, and conflict have engulfed Yemen into a situation that requires urgent action. This has been majorly caused due to closure of entry points for commercial import and destroyed infrastructure due to conflict as Yemen continues to face famine. American officials are also at risk of being charged for war crimes in international courts, for their direct or indirect involvement in the Yemeni conflict. It is the dire need of the hour to address this situation through changes in foreign policy by the United States toward the Yemeni conflict, in specific the logistical support for the Saudi-led coalition in Yemen.

Recommendations:

- Stop logistical support toward the Saudi-led coalition, including the sale of weapons.
- Provide humanitarian assistance either directly or through the Country-based Pooled Funds (CBPF) to Yemen, an effort by the United Nations.
- Ensure resources are directed in the entirety of Yemen by being the "police force" and the "mediating body."

Introduction to the Conflict

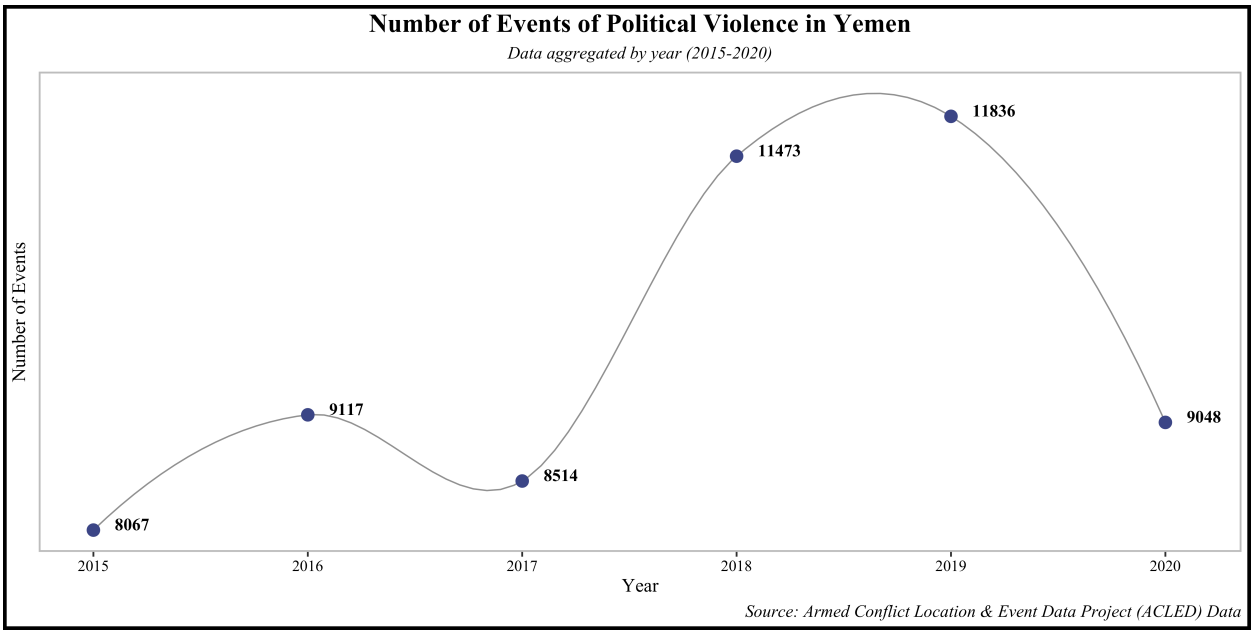

Figure 1: Number of Events of Political Conflict in Yemen (2015-2020)

"Yemen remains a tortured land, with its people ravaged in ways that should shock the conscience of humanity."

– Kamel Jendoubi, Chairperson, Group of Eminent Experts on Yemen, United Nations Human Rights Council

Over 127,000 people including 13,500 civilians have died since 2015 by targeted attacks majorly by the Saudi-led coalition in Yemen (Wong E., 2020). As seen in Figure 1, the number of violent events in Yemen has been only increasing since 2015 with a decrease in 2020, which could be attributed to disruptions in strategies caused due to the pandemic. In late 2016, the Obama administration had halted the sale of weapons to the Arab states in the Gulf. The Trump administration restarted the sale in 2017 when they also created a list of about 30,000 no-strike zones for the coalition which included hospitals and other civilian areas. The United States continues to assist Saudi Arabia in their bombing campaigns in Yemen. Representative Tom Malinowski, a Democrat from New Jersey's 7th congressional district has compared this situation to driving a car recklessly (Wong E., 2020) and asked a simple question, "If you were teaching me to drive for five years and I continued to hit passers-by, continued to total my car, would you continue to give me the keys?" In this situation, the driver is Saudi Arabia, while the car owner is the United States and the passengers are the Yemeni people.

The World Food Programme has reported that over 20 million Yemenis face food insecurity out of which over ten million are in an acute shortage of food. Due to the conflict–the destruction of infrastructure as well as rising costs of living, the country is faced with a famine-like never before. It relies on humanitarian relief in terms of monetary funding for food imports as well as food packages for meeting the needs of its people. Saudi Arabia continues to create blockades at major entry points such as ports making it almost impossible to receive essential goods such as food and water (Human Rights Watch, 2017). This, alongside the on-going conflict, has put an enormous strain on the accessibility of food and the availability of potable water.

Human Rights Violations

Representative Malinowski during his years as the former Assistant Secretary of State for Democracy, Human Rights, and Labor said that he had seen in 2016, a memo from the legal office of the State Department. The memo states that top agency officials including the Secretary of State could be charged with war crimes in Yemen due to having known the pattern of civilian killings by the Saudi government (Wong E., 2020). The list mentioned before that was a list of no-strike sites in Yemen was not followed by the Saudi airstrikes. They continued to target and attack civilian areas. The Group of Eminent International and Regional Experts on Yemen, a body of the United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC), in its third report reported, "some of the airstrikes conducted by the Coalition appear to have been undertaken without proper regard to principles of distinction, proportionality and precaution to protect civilians and civilian objects" (OHCHR, 2020). This is alarming, and action needs to be taken especially for protecting citizens of the United States against not only prosecution but also to reduce the harm caused (knowingly) by US citizens to the people of the Middle East.

Food Insecurity

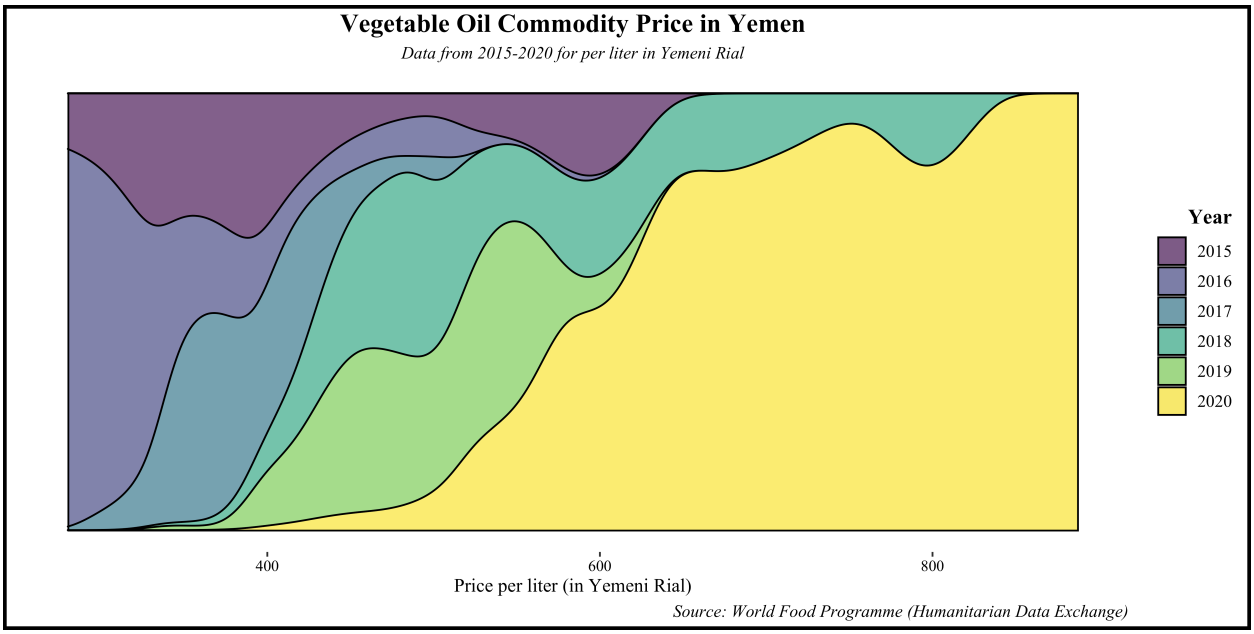

Figure 2: Vegetable Oil Commodity Prices in Yemen (in Yemeni Rial) (2015-2020)

Yemen has faced the problem of food security in certain areas even before the conflict escalated in 2015 (Alles L., 2017). It has since long imported 90 percent of its food, including staple food grains such as rice which is not cultivated in Yemen. Restrictions on imports, the sheer destruction of civilian infrastructure, and the lack of resources, jobs and money have just worsened the situation. Yemen being one of the most impoverished nations in the Middle East does not help either. This is more or less a direct result of the conflict. Lack of food security also poses a health risk especially due to the outbreak of Covid-19, where Yemen has already been affected by the Cholera outbreak. From a purely economic standpoint, due to such strain on resources, we see that the prices of food commodities would naturally go up as shown in Figure 2. We see that the prices of vegetable oil per liter in Yemeni Rial has been increasing since 2015 (depicted by purple), with the price almost doubling in 2020 (depicted by yellow), when compared to 2015. This is seen due to the density of the purple area being almost nothing following the ~640 Rial mark while the yellow area has a greater density which corresponds to the year 2020. This, coupled with less access to paid work due to the conflict has led to more and more people descending toward food insecurity. Yemen by its virtue of being in the Middle East has majorly arid, semi-arid, or desert areas. It is well known that soil that is not used for cultivation for long periods can lose its arability. If the current conflict is not brought to an end, it could render the country into a wide-spread famine due to the impossibility of cultivation soon.

Conclusion

Only a political solution can bring the war to an end and reinstate peace in Yemen. The continued support of the United States toward Saudi Arabia and its allies is only deteriorating the situation

further in terms of loss of human capital and also resources. The United Nations is making efforts by curbing extremist activities of non-state actors in Yemen (Houthi rebels), with the instrument of imposing sanctions. The focus of the United States should be on capacity-building and not aiding the destruction of Yemen. The United States needs to be at the forefront of this as it always has. One could speculate that if this conflict is not resolved sooner than later, it may worsen the situation in Yemen to an extent where conflict due to the need to secure food, water, and other necessities would also become prevalent in the near future.

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